THE UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG
FACULTY OF BUSINESS AND ECONOMICS

ECON6060 Development Economics

GENERAL INFORMATION

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Course Website: HKU Moodle

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course introduces the leading theories in development economics and their empirical applications. Our aim is to understand why some countries remain underdeveloped and the extent to which policies can shape growth and development. We will delve into particular topics of interest including, but not limited to, institutions, conflict, fertility, migration, health and others. As a result of taking the course, students are expected to understand both classic and frontier theories of economic development, and to be able to conduct preliminary research in an empirical fashion.

Each lecture topic will proceed as follows: We will start with a broad (mainly graphical) overview of recent macro trends followed by, whenever applicable, a walkthrough of simple, workhorse microeconomic models. Lastly, we end off each topic with an in-depth discussion of applied micro-economic studies from leading economics journals. For the last part, students are expected to have a basic understanding of applied econometric methods. To that end, given that there are no mandatory econometric pre-requisites, a single class will be devoted to giving a broad (largely non-mathematical/statistical) overview of methods that should be sufficient for understanding these papers.

We only have a single semester and hence, we will not be able to spend time going in-depth into each topic. Instead, the goal of this class is to give you a flavor of the main topics in development economics and how economists think about these issues.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

1: Acquisition and internalization of knowledge of the program discipline

2: Application and integration of knowledge

3: Inculcating professionalism and leadership

4: Developing global outlook

5: Mastering communication skills

PROGRAMME LEARNING OUTCOMES

PLO1: Understanding of fundamental theories and new development in economics

PLO2: Mastering of skills in analyzing economic data

PLO3: Demonstration of ability to apply economic knowledge and analytical skills to address policy and business problems with a global outlook

PLO4: Awareness of ethical concerns in economic issues

PLO5: Mastering of communication skills

COURSE LEARNING OUTCOMES

Course Learning Outcomes	**Aligned Programme Learning Outcomes**
CLO1: Acquaintance of the main theories and topics of development economics	PLO1, 2, 3
CLO2: Application of economic theory and empirical methods to examine various development issues	PLO1, 2, 3
CLO3: Developing a global outlook in the perspective of comparative development	PLO1, 2, 3, 4
CLO4: Communication and presentation skills	PLO1, 2, 3, 5

COURSE TEACHING AND LEARNING ACTIVITIES

Course Teaching and Learning Activities	**Expected Hour**	**Study Load (% of study)**
T&L1. Interactive lectures	30	23%
T&L2. Consultation: weekly consultation hours	10	8%
T&L3. Assignments	50	38%
T&L4. Lecture preparation & Self-study	40	31%
Total	[should range from 120 to 150]	100%

Assessment Methods	**Brief Description (Optional)**	**Weight**	**Aligned Course Learning Outcomes**
A1. In-class & forum participation	Attendance & discussions	20%	CLO1, 2, 4
	Effort and accuracy	30%	CLO1, 2, 3, 4
A2. Assignments	Effort and accuracy	50%	CLO1, 2, 4
A3. Final presentation			
	Total	100%	

STANDARDS FOR ASSESSMENT	
Course Grade Descriptors	
A+, A, A-	•Demonstrate a strong understanding of all relevant knowledge •Handling questions professionally •High participation in discussions •Present arguments that have an element of originality •Achieve a standard of excellent performance in the exams with very accurate computation and very good analytical and problem solving skills •Excellent performance in assignments
B+, B, B-	•Demonstrate a good understanding of all relevant knowledge •Handling questions in a logical way •Good participation in discussions •Present arguments that go beyond the lecture and textbook •Achieve a standard of good performance in the exams with accurate computation and good analytical and problem solving skills •Good performance in assignments
C+, C, C-	•Demonstrate a basic understanding of the concepts involved •Fairly address questions as set •Some participation in discussions •Present arguments in a well-structure manner •Meet a standard of acceptable performance in the exams with reasonably accurate computation and acceptable analytical and problem solving skills •Acceptable performance in assignments
D+, D	•Demonstrate a minimum understanding of the concepts involved •Barely address questions as set •Minimal or no participation in discussions •Present arguments in a marginally acceptable manner •Meet a standard of marginally acceptable performance in the exams with some errors in computation and barely adequate analytical and problem solving skills •Marginally acceptable performance in assignments
F	•Demonstrate a poor understanding of the concepts involved •Unable or unwilling to handle questions •Minimal or no participation in discussions •Present arguments poorly •Fail to meet a standard of passing the exams with major errors in computation and inadequate analytical and problem solving skills •Poorly performance in assignments
Assessment Rubrics for Participation	
A+, A, A-	•High participation in discussions •Always attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a strong understanding of all relevant knowledge •Handling questions professionally •Present arguments that have an element of originality •Respect others and follow the class rules (no chatting and do not use cell phone)
B+, B, B-	•Good participation in discussions •Often attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a good understanding of all relevant knowledge •Handling questions in a logical way •Present arguments that go beyond the lecture and textbook

	•Respect others and follow the class rules (no chatting and do not use cell phone)
C+, C, C-	•Some participation in discussions •Sometimes attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a basic understanding of the concepts involved •Fairly address questions as set •Present arguments in a well-structure manner •Respect others and follow the class rules (no chatting and do not use cell phone)
D+, D	•Minimal or no participation in discussions •Rarely attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a minimum understanding of the concepts involved •Barely address questions as set •Present arguments in a marginally acceptable manner •Respect others and follow the class rules (no chatting and do not use cell phone)
F	•Minimal or no participation in discussions •Almost never attend in-class discussions •Demonstrate a poor understanding of the concepts involved •Unable or unwilling to handle questions •Present arguments poorly •Behave poorly in class (often chatting with others, using cell phones, or being late)
Assessment Rubrics for Assignments and the Exam	
A+, A, A-	•Demonstrate a strong understanding of all relevant knowledge •Present arguments that have an element of originality •Achieve a standard of excellent performance in the assessments with very accurate computation and very good analytical and problem solving skills
B+, B, B-	•Demonstrate a good understanding of all relevant knowledge •Present arguments that go beyond the lecture and textbook •Achieve a standard of good performance in the assessments with accurate computation and good analytical and problem solving skills
C+, C, C-	•Demonstrate a basic understanding of the concepts involved •Present arguments in a well-structure manner •Meet a standard of acceptable performance in the assessments with reasonably accurate computation and acceptable analytical and problem solving skills
D+, D	•Demonstrate a minimum understanding of the concepts involved •Present arguments in a marginally acceptable manner •Meet a standard of marginally acceptable performance in the assessments with some errors in computation and barely adequate analytical and problem solving skills
F	•Demonstrate a poor understanding of the concepts involved •Present arguments poorly •Fail to meet a standard of passing the assessments with major errors in computation and inadequate analytical and problem solving skills
COURSE CONTENT AND TENTATIVE TEACHING SCHEDULE	
1. Assignments: 1) pertinence, clarity, and reasoning, 2) the depth of analysis, 3) originality/novelty of your own comments/critiques/extension (for review work), and 4) writing and layout.	

2. Presentation: : 1) the originality, pertinence, and clarity of the topic, 2) the clarity of framework and reasoning, 3) the suitability/reliability of data/materials and research methods, 4) the depth of analysis, 5) the performance in the lecture and Q&A, and 6) the quality/layout of the PPT.

Group Projects (see schedule for additional details):
Presentation #1: May 15/19 (tentative)
Due date of outline: May 22
Presentation #2: June 2 and June 5

You should form groups of **three to five members** each. Let me know if you are having trouble finding a group. For Presentation #1, each group should select a single academic paper. For Presentation #2, each group should select a developing country to focus on, and work on this in parallel with the class.

Presentation #1 should focus on summarizing the chosen paper, paying particular attention to (i) the literature review (usually in the introduction section) so as to explain to us the key novel contributions of the paper relative to the existing literature; (ii) the relevant institutional background of the setting; (iii) the identification/empirical method used (iv) the results; (v) 4-5 key comments and/or criticisms of any parts of the paper.

The first part of Presentation #2 should provide a macroeconomic perspective on development trends in the country over the past few decades, using various development indicators and a historical perspective. It should conclude with an assessment of development prospects in the near future. The second part of Presentation #2 should be a policy brief: select a key policy area for this country, search the literature for important research findings, summarize these and make some policy recommendations. If you're working on a larger country (e.g. China and India), feel free to zoom in on particular regions or provinces.

To encourage an early start, an outline will be due before **23:59 May 22**. The outline will not be graded: all submissions will automatically get the full 10% credit. However, failure or delay in submitting an outline would result in a penalty of 5-points.

Presentation. Presentations will take place in the middle of, and at the end of the semester. Each group will be randomly assigned a day/time and the final presentation schedules will be announced on Moodle.

The title page of the slides should have the names of group members in order of presentation. The grading is based on both content and performance in presentation. Each group has 25- 30minutes (subject to final class enrolment and number of groups), in which 20-25 minutes for presentation and 5 minutes for Q & A. Presentation times will be strictly enforced. Audiences are encouraged to participate actively during the discussion in the Q & A session.

Homework. There will be **two homework assignments.** These will be posted on Moodle along with due dates. You can work in groups and each group is required to submit only one copy. Write the names and university ID numbers of all group members clearly on the first page. Assignments are due at the end (23:59) of the designated day – please submit them on time. You will get no credit for turning in assignments after the due date. The assignments will reinforce concepts from the lectures and readings. They will serve as an opportunity to study concepts that will be relevant for the final policy solution presentation. I strongly encourage you to work through the problems independently before working together as a group.

Feedback: You are highly encouraged to provide me with feedback as we progress through the course (e.g. is the class proceeding at too fast a pace?) You can come to my office hours, email me, or post suggestions or requests on the Moodle forum. Please remember to fill out the end-of-semester feedback as well.

Office hours: If the stipulated time doesn't work for you, please let me know and I'll send you a link via https://youcanbook.me/ for which you can book a suitable time-lot. Do also let me know whether you prefer in-person or Zoom. Note: If Zoom, I will be online only at times that students set up consultation.

Email policy:

1. All emails should have the subject header [ECON6060]: [Insert subject of discussion here]
2. Please try to avoid lengthy questions on lecture/problem set material through email. It's ok if it's a quick clarification but deeper questions should be avoided. Instead, these questions should be posted on the Moodle forum so that everyone can benefit from the answer and have the opportunity to discuss. Alternatively, in-depth questions can be asked during office hours.
3. Please restrict email communication to administrative and personal matters: e.g. medical certs, office hour appointments, project group appointments etc.

I will strive to reply to your emails within 48-72 hours

REQUIRED/RECOMMENDED READINGS & ONLINE MATERIALS (e.g. journals, textbooks, website addresses etc.)

The course materials are made up of book chapters and articles. Please see the schedule for the complete reading list. Materials with an asterisk (*) are required to read before class, whereas the others are optional for your interests to dig deeper. The specific pages and chapters of the readings are clearly indicated in the class schedule.

Textbook
Development Economics. Debraj Ray. Princeton University Press, 1998.

Recommended Reading
Understanding Poverty. Abhijit Banerjee, Roland Benabou, and Dilip Mookherjee, editors. Oxford University Press, 2006.

DETAILED READINGS: See class schedule

MEANS/PROCESSES FOR STUDENT FEEDBACK ON COURSE

- Online response via Moodle site
- Others: ___SFTL_____ (please specify)

COURSE POLICY (e.g. plagiarism, academic honesty, attendance, etc.)

1. Email communications should be limited to short messages providing basic information or requesting urgent clarifications. Please include "ECON6060" in the subject line. Take advantage of class time and office hours to bring up any substantial concerns. I find that it is more constructive to address these issues in person.

2. Students should complete assigned readings before each class and come prepared to discuss them. Participation in class discussions is a core component of the learning process.

3. The University Regulations on academic dishonesty will be strictly enforced! Please check the University Statement on plagiarism on the web: http://www.hku.hk/plagiarism/

o Academic dishonesty is behavior in which a deliberately fraudulent misrepresentation is employed in an attempt to gain undeserved intellectual credit, either for oneself or for another. It includes, but is not necessarily limited to, the following type of case:

o a. Plagiarism - The representation of someone else's ideas as if they are one's own. Where the arguments, data, designs, etc., of someone else are being used in a paper, report, oral presentation, or similar academic project, this fact must be made explicitly clear by citing the appropriate references. The references must fully indicate the extent to which any parts of the project are not one's own work. Paraphrasing of someone else's ideas is still using someone else's ideas, and must be acknowledged.

o b. Unauthorized Collaboration on Out-of-Class Projects - The representation of work as solely one's own when in fact it is the result of a joint effort. Where a candidate for a degree or other award uses the work of another person or persons without due acknowledgement:

o 1. The relevant Board of Examiners may impose a penalty in relation to the seriousness of the offence;

o 2. The relevant Board of Examiners may report the candidate to the Senate, where there is prima facie evidence of an intention to deceive and where sanctions beyond those in (1) might be invoked.

4. Requests for re-grades must be put in writing and submitted to me/the TA within a week of receiving an initial grade. The goal of assignments is to enhance students' understanding of course material. Grades should not be seen as an end in themselves.

5. If you miss an exam without legitimate reason and advance notice, you will receive a grade of zero. If you miss an exam for a legitimate reason, and you have notified me in advance, we will handle your absence as per university policy.

ADDITIONAL COURSE INFORMATION (e.g. e-learning platforms & materials, penalty for late assignments, etc.)

Assignments will be submitted in class before the lectures. No late assignment will be accepted.
Lecture notes and self-learning materials will be uploaded on Moodle.
Good questions and discussions on Moodle will be awarded participation grades.